

Portraits

Before the invention of photography, painted, sculpted or drawn portraits were the only way to record appearances. From the Latin word *protrahere*, meaning 'to draw forth or bring to light', they have been made for thousands of years in a variety of media to show sitters' likenesses and character. They often show qualities such as power, influence, beauty, wealth or learning. Some of the earliest portraits were painted on wooden boards attached to Egyptian mummies from the early first century CE. Realistic portraits of important figures were also common in ancient Roman sculpture. Although most portraits have been of rulers, more recently 'ordinary' people have been represented. Fashions in portrait styles change. In the Early Renaissance, the classical profile view became customary, then the more complex three-quarter view, showing more of the face, became common. Probably the most famous portrait, Leonardo's *Mona Lisa*, conveys different aspects of the young woman's personality at once. Most portraits flatter their sitters, but some, such as Goya's portraits of the Spanish royal family, are candid and uncomplimentary.



Raphael, *Lorenzo di Medici*, c.1519